

Americans want more trains: Amtrak sees record ridership

The arrival of new trainsets, renewed lines, and refurbished stations indicates that train travel in America is poised for growth.

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An Amtrak train passing through Alvise.

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Amtrak saw [record](#) ridership in FY2025 and is on track to have another record year. In FY2026, [23.9 million people rode Amtrak](#) trains, 6%

more than one year ago.

Americans are switching to trains for many reasons, including, recently, increasing gas prices and air fares. Recent improvements in Amtrak service create the potential for further ridership increases in the years to come – if the federal government matches Americans’ increasing desire for train travel with consistent investment.

The great train rebound

Amtrak was founded by Congress in [1970](#) to save passenger rail service in the United States. It has seen overall growth since then, especially with the introduction of electrified high-speed rail Northeast Corridor (NEC) service, [Acela, in 2000](#).

The COVID-19 pandemic cut into Amtrak service and ridership, but the service has seen consistent growth since then, including a [5.1% increase in ridership from FY2024 to FY2025](#). In May 2026, gas prices remained [high](#), and [Amtrak’s performance reports](#) showed a 6% increase in ridership compared to last year, when gas prices were 39% lower.

The reasons for the ridership increase do not lie solely in the spike in gas prices; Amtrak has been seeing strong growth for years now. With improved infrastructure, newer trains, and people who are eager to ride them, Amtrak is an increasingly important and desirable option for travelers.

In 2021, Amtrak was directly awarded [\\$22 billion](#) over five years by the federal government as part of the Bipartisan Infrastructure Law, boosting spending capacity for an organization that has always been [underfunded](#). A big chunk of the [funding](#) has gone to purchasing new trains to renew and expand the [Acela](#) fleet, with trains that run 10 mph faster, and for [Amtrak Airo](#) trains, which will be used in the Eastern United States and the Pacific Northwest. Additional funding has been allocated to renewing stations such as [Moynihan Hall at Penn Station](#), [Baltimore Penn Station](#), and other [infrastructure projects](#) such as bridge and tunnel maintenance. Amtrak has also worked to make its stations more accessible, with [155](#) stations fully or partially ADA compliant. Their goal is to be fully accessible by [2029](#).

NEC trains are Amtrak’s [money-maker](#), since they connect densely populated, large urban areas from Washington, D.C. to Boston. But state-supported and long-distance trains have also played an important role in Amtrak’s increased ridership. [State-supported trains](#), which must be under 750 miles, are largely funded by state governments; Amtrak advertises and runs the trains, but it is the states that set ticket prices and timetables and support day-to-day operations. These state-supported trains saw a [9%](#) increase in year-to-date ridership from FY May 2025 to FY May 2026.

Passengers flock to revamped service

In recent years, Amtrak has even restored or expanded service along key corridors. After 20 years of closure, Amtrak reopened the service on the Gulf Coast with the new [Mardi Gras line](#), which connects New Orleans to Mobile in about four hours. Projected to have [60,000 passengers](#) in its first year of operation, the system saw ridership reach [100,000](#) in under eight months. Besides offering a great, cheap option for weekend getaways, it has boosted [economic renewal](#) in smaller towns like Bay St. Louis, MS. Symbolically, it shows another step towards [healing](#) in the region, which was slammed by Hurricane Katrina, ultimately stopping the service.

Another renewal project like this happened on the [Borealis line](#) from St. Paul to Chicago, which is two years old and added a [second](#) daily train between the two northern cities. From 2024 to 2025, ridership grew by [140%](#), shattering [expectations](#). The Borealis service is competitive with driving and air travel on cost. With one-way plane fares between Minneapolis and Chicago averaging around \$60, Amtrak tickets can go as low as \$41, considering they are [bought in advance](#).

If there are trains, Americans will ride them

While Amtrak service is not always fast or reliable, trains do have advantages over other forms of travel. Unlike airports, train stations are often in city centers, making them easier to get to, while trains tend to offer more comfort than increasingly cramped accommodations in planes. Trains are also more [environmentally friendly](#), which has contributed to their popularity, especially amongst younger people. All of this goes without mentioning the beautiful [views](#) that can be taken in along the way.

Americans deserve more trains. While the country is far from having a robust national rail network, small steps are being taken that offer hope. In 2023, [Brightline](#), a privately owned rail company, began operating trains from Miami to Orlando, running on a business model [“for travel routes that are too long to drive, but too short to fly.”](#) They have reported [16% and 17%](#) increases in year-to-date revenue and ridership, respectively, and plan to launch service from Las Vegas to Los Angeles with [Brightline West](#) in [late 2029](#).

Despite recent progress, however, Amtrak's future remains uncertain. The proposed [transportation bill](#) in the U.S. House of Representatives would cut federal funding for passenger rail by [43% compared with the 2021 Bipartisan Infrastructure Law](#) and provides [no guaranteed baseline funding](#), leaving Amtrak to rely on annual appropriations cycles. Cutting federal funding could make it harder to maintain passenger rail's recent momentum and give more Americans the option of traveling by rail.

Train travel continues to increase, and although it is not perfect, improvements are being made. Due to the sheer size of the United States, it will always be difficult to connect the country's edges by train, but by starting with smaller regional rail connections, we can begin to shift our travel away from cars and planes. In 2024, Amtrak set a goal to reach [66 million](#) passengers by FY2040. As newer trains are put into

service and tracks are fixed, Amtrak has the opportunity to reach new heights and provide more travel options for more people across America.

** Correction: An earlier version of this post incorrectly stated that Brightline’s trains in Florida are “fully electric.” They are diesel-electric.*

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